Strong Typhoon Champi Brings Wind and Rain Near Taiwan

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Hundreds of flights in East Asia were cancelled on Friday as **Typhoon** Champi moved close to Taiwan's north-east coast. A **typhoon** is the name for a powerful tropical storm in this part of the Pacific Ocean, like a hurricane in the Atlantic.

Authorities said one person died after being swept away by waves. The storm also injured 171 people, and about 1,000 people left their homes to stay safe.

Earlier this week, Champi was the strongest storm on the planet so far this year. Its steady winds reached 185 miles per hour over the Philippine Sea, which is as strong as a **Category 5 hurricane**. It later weakened. On Friday afternoon, its wind **gusts** were about 119 miles per hour.

Weather agencies in Taiwan, Hong Kong and Japan expected the center of the storm, called the eye, to pass by without coming onto land in Taiwan. But a Taiwanese **forecaster** said this could not be completely ruled out if the storm stalls or wobbles.

Rain was expected to be heaviest on Saturday morning and to continue until Saturday evening. Officials asked people to stay away from coasts and mountains.

Work and classes were called off on Friday in nearly all of Taiwan's 22 **counties** and cities. People there call this a "**typhoon** holiday." Only Kinmen county, a group of islands west of the main island, kept schools and offices open.

In Japan's Okinawa area, nearly 8,400 homes lost power, and more than 160 flights were cancelled by four Japanese airlines. Heavy rain and wind also reached Batanes, Philippine islands south of Taiwan.

Champi is Japan's 30th **typhoon** this year, the most since 2013. Experts link the busy season to an unusually strong **El Niño**, a natural warming of the Pacific Ocean that happens every few years and can change weather around the world.

Word Treasure

typhoon -- A powerful tropical storm in the western Pacific Ocean, similar to a hurricane.

Category 5 hurricane -- The strongest level on the scale used to rate hurricanes by wind speed.

gusts -- Sudden, short bursts of strong wind.

forecaster -- A scientist who predicts the weather.

counties -- Local areas within a country or state that have their own government.

El Niño -- A natural warming of the Pacific Ocean every few years that can change weather around the world.

Background you need

Typhoons are giant spinning storms that form over warm ocean water in the western Pacific; in the Atlantic, the same kind of storm is called a hurricane.

Their strength is measured by wind speed, and the strongest ones match a Category 5 hurricane.

Places often hit by typhoons, such as Taiwan, Japan and the Philippines, close schools and offices and warn people to avoid coasts so they stay safe.

El Niño is a natural pattern in which Pacific Ocean water grows warmer than usual, which can feed stronger or more frequent storms in some regions.

Break it down

LEAD: Typhoon Champi nears Taiwan's north-east coast, cancelling hundreds of flights
IMPACT: One person died after being swept away by waves; 171 injured; about 1,000 evacuated
STORM STRENGTH: Strongest storm of the year earlier this week (185 mph), weaker by Friday (gusts 119 mph)
FORECAST: Eye expected to pass without landfall, but forecasters cannot rule it out
+- WHEN: Heaviest rain Saturday morning, lasting until Saturday evening
+- ADVICE: Stay away from coasts and mountains
RESPONSE: "Typhoon holiday" closes work and classes almost everywhere except Kinmen county
REGIONAL EFFECTS: Power cuts and flight cancellations in Okinawa; heavy rain in Batanes
CAUSE: Japan's 30th typhoon this year, linked to an unusually strong El Niño
OPEN QUESTION: Whether the storm stalls or wobbles toward land

Why it matters

A very active typhoon season shows how ocean patterns like El Niño can affect millions of people, and how warnings, closures and evacuations help keep communities safe.

Test what you remember

1. What happened to many flights in East Asia on Friday?

- (A) They were cancelled
- (B) They were moved to Saturday morning
- (C) They were made free
- (D) They flew faster

2. How strong were Champi's steady winds at its peak?

- (A) 119 miles per hour
- (B) 300 miles per hour
- (C) 50 miles per hour
- (D) 185 miles per hour

3. What do people in Taiwan call a day when work and classes stop because of a storm?

- (A) A typhoon holiday
- (B) A storm break
- (C) A wind week
- (D) A rain day

4. Which place in Taiwan kept work and classes going as usual?

- (A) Liuqiu island
- (B) Kinmen county
- (C) Taipei
- (D) Okinawa

5. About how many households in Okinawa lost power?

- (A) Nearly 8,400
- (B) More than 160
- (C) 1,000
- (D) 171

6. What do experts link to this year's busy typhoon season?

- (A) Melting glaciers in Taiwan
- (B) A volcano
- (C) A solar eclipse
- (D) An unusually strong El Niño

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: A 4: B 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Weather agencies in Taiwan, Hong Kong and Japan: Forecast that the eye of the storm would pass without making landfall in Taiwan.

2. A Taiwanese forecaster: Said landfall could not be completely ruled out if the storm stalls or wobbles.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):